

בְּרֵאשִׁית

Bereshit

Genesis 1:1–6:8 — Creation, Eden, Cain and Abel, ten generations to Noah

Mega Bible
parasha sheet
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THE PARASHA BY THE NUMBERS

146

VERSES

1931

WORDS

368

DISTINCT ROOTS

5

HAPAX LEGOMENA

MOST FREQUENT ROOTS

אֱלֹהִים	67
God	
הָיָה	62
to be, become	
כָּל	53
all, every	
שָׁנָה	50
year	
אָמַר	42
he said	
יָלַד	42
he begot, bore	
יוֹם	37
day	
אָדָם	36
man, Adam	
ה'	36
the Name (Hashem)	
אָרֶץ	35
land, earth	

WHAT THE PARASHA CALLS GOD

אֱלֹהִים	67
God	
ה'	36
the Name (Hashem)	

Just two names carry the whole parasha: אֱלֹהִים (Elohim) for the work of creation itself, and ה' once the story turns to the Garden, the first commandment, and Cain — the same two-name pattern the classical commentators read as *din* (judgment) giving way to *rachamim* (mercy).

Averaging **13.2 words** a verse. The longest verse is **2:19** at 28 words — Adam naming every animal one by one; the shortest, **2:1**, has only 5 — the whole of heaven and earth, finished.

FIVE WORDS THAT OCCUR NOWHERE ELSE IN THE BIBLE

2:11 פִּישׁוֹן	H6376	3:19 בִּזְעָתָּה <זָעָה>	H2188
Pishon (river name)		in the sweat of	
4:16 נֹד	H5113	4:20 יָבָל	H2989
Nod (land name, "wandering")		Jabal (name)	
4:21 יוֹבָל	H3106		
Jubal (name)			

Hapax legomena, counted against the whole Tanakh: five of this parasha's 368 roots are used exactly once in all of Scripture, and 149 more appear only once here. Three of the five are proper names (Pishon, Nod, Jabal, Jubal) — Bereshit's ordinary vocabulary is ordinary precisely because it is laying the foundation everything else is built from; its rarest words turn up naming rivers, exiles, and a handful of Cain's own descendants.

1:2 תהו ובהו

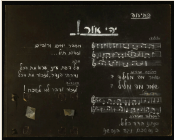
the uncreated world's "formless void" becomes the everyday word for utter chaos and mess

וְהָאֵרֶץ הִתְהוּ תְהוֹ וְבְהוֹ — before the first act of creation, the earth is תהו ובהו, a rhyming pair found nowhere else with this exact sense: shapeless, unformed, not-yet-anything. It describes a state prior to order, not a mess made by disorder. Modern Hebrew flattens the distinction: תוהו ובוהו now just means chaos or a mess — a messy desk, a chaotic office, a disorganized plan are all תוהו ובוהו. Israeli publishers have used the phrase as the title of children's books, political pamphlets ("תוהו ובוהו מדיני", on the political chaos of pre-state settlement) and literary essay collections, always trading on the same everyday sense of disorder rather than the specific pre-creation void of the verse.

1:3 יְהִי אוֹר

the first divine speech-act becomes a ceremonial phrase for new beginnings and dedications

וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹהִים יְהִי אוֹר וַיְהִי אוֹר — the first words God speaks, and the first recorded instance of speech bringing something into being. יְהִי אוֹר ("let there be light") became a stock phrase for inauguration and renewal in modern Hebrew: building dedications, new institutions, and communal ceremonies invoke it as a way of marking a beginning. The National Library's archive of the Dalia Dance Festival — the mass folk-dance gatherings of the Kibbutz movement in the 1940s–50s — preserves a musical number literally titled "יהי אור", its lyrics and score handwritten in white ink on black paper, using the verse as the festival's own opening flourish.



Dalia Dance Festival Archive (Kibbutz Dalia), National Library of Israel FL122898082

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יהי אור!

Words and music for "Let there be light!", from the Dalia Dance Festival archive — a folk-dance movement's own creation-themed opening number.

4:9 הַשֹּׁמֵר אֶחִי אֲנִכִּי

Cain's evasive question becomes the name of a real Israeli advocacy movement

וַיֹּאמֶר לֹא יָדַעְתִּי הֲשֹׁמֵר אֶחִי אֲנִכִּי — Cain's defensive deflection, asked instead of answering for his brother, is one of the Torah's most quoted rhetorical questions: an evasion so famous it now reads as an assertion of responsibility rather than a denial of it. "שומר אחי אנוכי" ("I am my brother's keeper") was the actual name of an international campaign organization active from the late 1970s through the 1980s advocating for Soviet Refuseniks, including Natan Sharansky — the National Library's archives hold its posters, notebooks, and campaign files under that name. A 1971 caricature by the Israeli cartoonist Dosh, drawn for Maariv, put the original question mark back: "שומר אחי אנוכי?!", turning Cain's excuse into a live challenge about international indifference — it survives in the Dosh Archive, though under a restricted-access license that keeps it off this page.

THE SEVEN DAYS, BY WORD COUNT

אֹר	רָקִיעַ	יִבְשָׁה וְצִמָּח	מֵאֲרוֹת	דָּגָה וְעוֹף	חַיָּה וָאָדָם	שָׁבַת
Day 1 — light 52 words	Day 2 — sky 38 words	Day 3 — land & plants 69 words	Day 4 — sun, moon, stars 69 words	Day 5 — sea & sky creatures 57 words	Day 6 — land animals & humans 149 words	Day 7 — rest 35 words

Day Six runs longer than any other two days combined. It is the only day with two separate creative acts — land animals, then humanity — and the only day the text pauses to explain itself: God's own likeness, dominion over the earth, and what everything alive is given to eat. The seventh day is the shortest workday of the week precisely because nothing is made on it at all.

MY NOTES

Nothing recorded yet — the notes field is empty for every verse of Genesis 1–6.